

Furman Political Thought Club Constitution

Article I

Name

The name of this organization shall be the Furman University Political Thought Club. Commonly referred to as “PTC.”

Article II

Purpose

To promote civilized, informed and enlightened political discussion that strengthens rather than divides, informs rather than confounds, and ennobles rather than degrades the Furman community and beyond. To recruit new members and encourage participation in cordial yet invigorating conversation, focused on serious engagement with texts on political thought. To hold meetings where students lead and participate in discussions about historical ideas, eternal questions, and current topics in political thought.

Article III

Affiliations

This club is formally affiliated with the Department of Politics and International Affairs. This organization is a recognized organization at Furman University and adheres to all University policies as set forth in the Furman University Student Handbook.

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Article IV

Membership

In keeping with Furman University’s non-discrimination policies, membership shall be open to all undergraduate, day students. Our organization will not discriminate on the basis of race, sex, handicap, age, sexual orientation, political affiliation, or religious affiliation.

No requirements are needed to join PTC other than being a member of the Furman community.

Article V

Officers

The leadership titles are the following: President, Vice President, Secretary, and Treasurer. In order to serve as an officer, one must show a significant interest in political thought by (1) consistently attending Political Thought Club meetings, and/or (2) extensively discussing political thought with the Faculty Advisor and the Officers. The officers shall be appointed by the student leadership with the consent of the Faculty Advisor.

Normally, an officer shall serve for one academic year in their specific office, including both the Fall and Spring semesters. However, in special circumstances, such as graduation and study abroad, an officer shall only serve for one semester and another member shall be selected to serve as officer for the following semester.

Article VI

Advisor

The faculty advisor shall assist the officers in curating the readings, and provide suggestions on which topics and readings would lead to insightful discussion. They will also participate in discussions whenever they are available.

Article VII

Meetings

Meetings will regularly occur weekly on Friday from 4:00-5:00 pm. Typically, the President and the Faculty Advisor will co-lead the discussions, which centers on reading, interpreting, and discussing the assigned texts.

Article VIII

Finance

The organization will receive funding through SGA. Active members are not expected to pay dues.

Article VII

Amendments

Any change to the constitution will be enacted through a unanimous decision of the student leadership and the Faculty Advisor. In the event of a disagreement, the majority opinion will be enacted.

BYLAWS

Article I: Membership

All individuals who attend Political Thought Club are considered members. There are no other categories of members, and their membership is not accompanied by responsibilities. To qualify as a member, one must be a member of the Furman community and attend multiple meetings. If a member has shown consistent hostile or uncollegial behavior, they will be removed from the club. The process of removing a member will consist of the following: (1) the leadership and Faculty Advisor will meet to ensure that the member's behavior warrants removal, (2) the member will be notified that they have lost their membership, (3) they will be removed from the email list, (4) they will be emailed privately by all of leadership and the Faculty Advisor collectively, notifying them that they are no longer permitted to attend PTC meetings.

Article II: Selection of Officers

Officers will be selected from the members of PTC by current leadership with the consent of Faculty Advisor. When an officer position is vacant, or soon to be vacant, all members will be notified that the position is open. The leadership and the Faculty Advisor will deliberate for a week to determine which member will fill the vacant position. After a week, the member will be notified that they have been appointed to the position, as well as the members as a whole. The notifications will be emailed through the emailing list by the President.

1. **President:** To preside over and lead all meetings of the club in cooperation with the Faculty Advisor when available; to administer the club program in such a manner that it meets the purpose outlined in Article II; to make the final decisions for the readings of the year in cooperation with the Advisor; to send emails to everyone on the email list regarding reminders of what readings will be discussed and to alert everyone when the meeting is at a different time, location, or canceled; to represent the club, especially in matters regarding SGA.

2. **Vice President:** To preside in the absence of the president; to aid the President in other tasks the President may assign; to educate members of the club on the club's constitution; to fill in for any missing officers or provide them aid when needed; to provide background information on the texts and authors for the assigned readings at the meeting; to curate, monitor, and invite members to social media platforms such as GroupMe. The Vice President will have sole administrative control over social media platforms which includes the authority to add members and remove them based on their conduct.

3. **Secretary:** To record the number of people who attend each meeting; to print out the texts of the readings; to provide a summary of the discussion; to update and curate the Political Thought Club's Furman email list; to organize events in cooperation with the Treasurer.

4. **Treasurer:** To timely submit check and reimbursement requests to SGA; to prepare and keep track of the yearly budget; to make financial reports to all club meetings; to distribute club funds upon authorization by the president; to manage any other financial matters of the club; to purchase and manage the various refreshments for each club meeting; to help organize, run, and staff any club events held throughout the year.

If a role remains vacant at the beginning of an academic year, the leadership will attempt to fill the vacancy as promptly as possible according to rules set out in Article II. During the time of vacancy, a sitting officer may take on the responsibilities of the vacant office.

A longer process will occur if an officer needs to be removed from their position due to negligence or abuse of their office. A club member must meet with the Faculty Advisor to disclose the allegations. If the allegations are in violation of university policy, the Faculty Advisor will contact the appropriate office in the university. Second, the advisor will privately meet with this officer to discuss the allegations. The advisor will then discuss with the club leadership the appropriate course of action. If the advisor determines that no wrong-doing was committed, the process ends here and the officer will not be removed from their position. If the advisor determines that the officer must be removed, they will notify the officer that they will be immediately removed from their position.

Article III: Selection of Advisor

The advisor must be a faculty member of the Department of Politics and International Affairs in the subfield of Political Thought at Furman University. The President will choose a faculty member meeting this requirement if they would like to accept the position as advisor.

The advisor may be removed from this position if they show hostile behaviors towards any of the members, attempts to prevent the leadership from fulfilling the obligations of their office, or does not adhere to their responsibilities described in article VI for a period of one semester without a justifiable excuse (such as illness or family emergencies). To remove the faculty advisor, the student leadership must come to a unanimous consensus.

Article IV: Committees

What committees (or similar) will be established?

What are the functions and duties of each?

What is the process for establishing ad-hoc committees?

Article V: Rules of Order

Business will be conducted in the following way:

1. The members will meet at 4:00 pm until 5:00 pm on Fridays.
2. The club will interpret and discuss an assigned reading on political thought which they will have received a week before the meeting.
3. The Treasurer will prepare refreshments, if available.
4. The Secretary records the number of members present, and summarizes the discussion from the previous meeting, if applicable.
5. The President, along with the Faculty Advisor, will lead group discussion.
6. At 5:00 pm, the meeting will adjourn.

Conflicts not in violation of university policy will be resolved by the leadership after receiving the approval of the Dean of Students. First, a one-on-one discussion with the conflicting members will ensure. If the conflict impacts the club as a whole, then the leadership as a collective shall convene to discuss the matter. If a mediator is needed in any of these discussions, a student officer or the Faculty Advisor may assume said role. For the process of removing members due to a conflict see Article I.

Organizations may not address a member's violations of university policy via internal standards boards or other accountability mechanisms without prior approval of the Dean of Students Office. Conduct expectations unique to membership in the organization and that do not overlap or otherwise interfere with university authority may be addressed with the written approval of the AVP/Dean of Students or designee. Groups affiliated with national organizations that have established guidance and procedures over disciplinary matters, may follow the directive of those national organizations with regard to member conduct but must do so with written approval of the university.

Article VI: Amendments

Any change to the bylaws can be done through a unanimous decision of the student leadership and the Faculty Advisor.